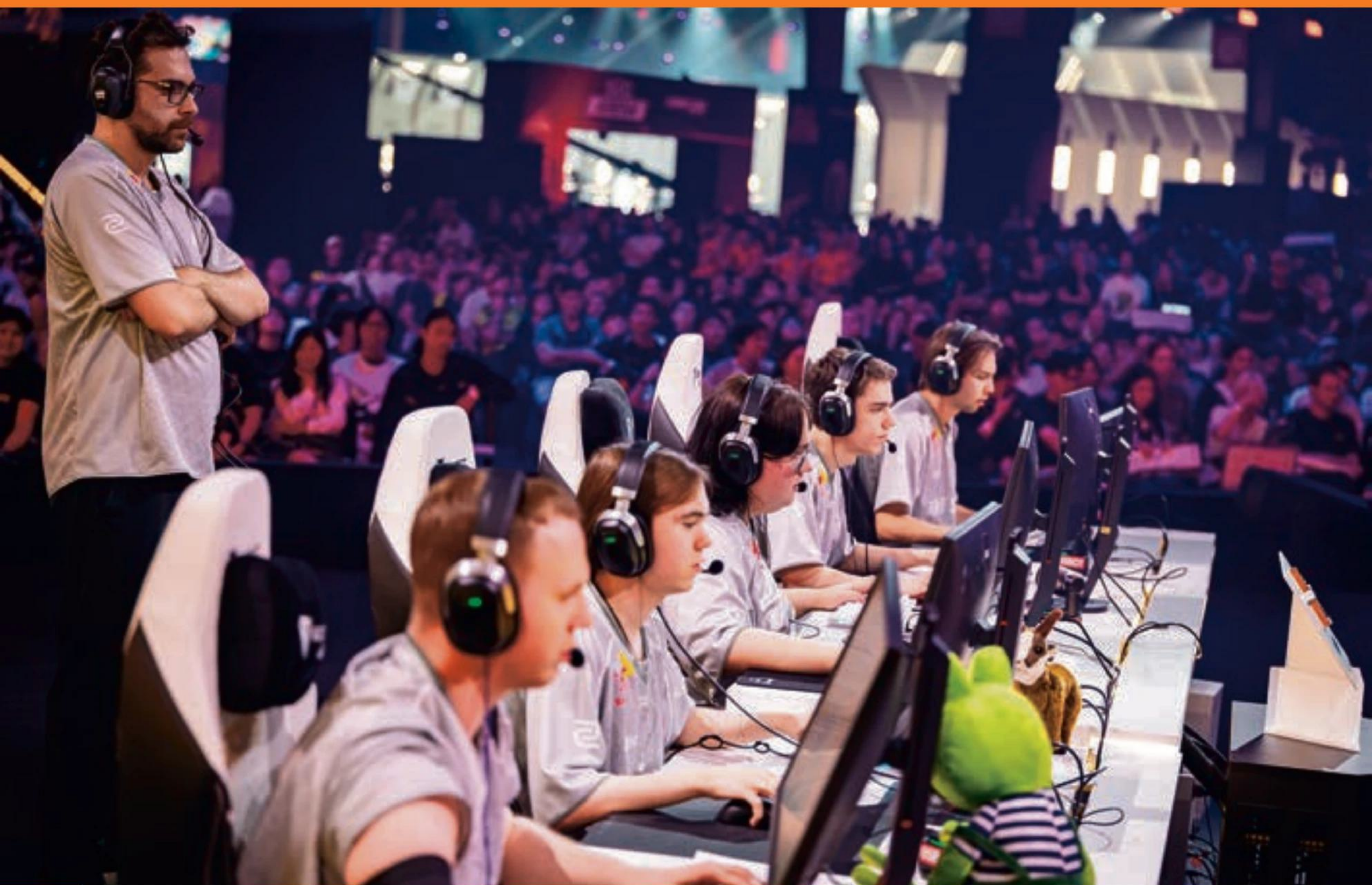




Laser focus: Team Spirit (in pic) defeated Team Vitality 2-1 in the Counter-Strike 2 quarterfinal round. ESPORTS WORLD CUP MEDIA/ESPORTS FOUNDATION

Esports Charts, excluding viewers from China, where data was unavailable.

Liberté, égalité, fraternité

At the tournament, gaming was not a distraction. It was an avenue for freedom, equality — physical stature did not matter, reflexes did — and fraternity, with hundreds gathering to discuss games and streaming communities. In other words, it embodied France's national motto: *Liberté, égalité, fraternité* (Liberty, equality and fraternity).

Fans aged between 19 and 46 were seen holding banners for teams such as Gentle Mates, M8 and Karmine Corp, while collective boos echoed around the stadium for

Ninjas in Pyjamas, a team that reportedly moved out of Europe recently.

In packed auditoriums filled with the smell of dry ice, applause and collective sighs rang out in front of giant screens.

This, right there, was what a World Cup meant — the banter, rivalry, heartbreak and drama.

"I am interested in Rocket League, Valorant and sometimes Counter-Strike. I tried to go to the main game that I follow, which is Rocket League. So, I already knew some of the teams which were playing, and I was supporting K-Corp (Karmine Corp), which reached the semifinals," says Yanis Thoraud, a 24-year-old esports enthusiast from Paris.

"Unfortunately, they lost to the Falcons. It was the first time for me to see the ambience, the big screens, and people celebrating and being able to live this in person in a giant room, in front of the players, is a

thousand times better than watching them on screen... This seemed like a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to witness these types of games."

Old finds a new home

An intriguing subplot of the World Cup was the presence of an ancient sport — chess — bridging the old and the new, traditional sports and esports. It was here that some of India's most promising prospects competed, with four Grandmasters in contention: Arjun Erigaisi for Gen.G Esports and Nihal Sarin, Aravindh Chithambaram and Pranesh M for S8UL Esports.

Erigaisi and Sarin, friends off the board, faced each other in the opening round, with the former walking away with the win. However, both ended their campaigns in the quarterfinals, losing to Hikaru Nakamura and eventual champion Magnus Carlsen, respectively.

Meanwhile, Aravindh exited in the play-ins, while Pranesh was knocked